



MODULE 7

Team dynamics and cohesion

| Are you building a group of athletes, or a real team?

CORE THEORY

Group cohesion in sport has two dimensions (Carron et al., 1985): task cohesion (working together toward a goal) and social cohesion (liking each other). Both matter, but task cohesion is the stronger predictor of performance. Tuckman's stage model (Forming → Storming → Norming → Performing → Adjourning) describes how teams grow. Coaches who avoid or suppress the Storming phase artificially keep their team in the Norming phase, without real connection.

Source: Carron et al. (1985) · Tuckman (1965) · Lencioni (2002) · Festinger et al. (1950)

"Individual commitment to a group effort, that is what makes a team work, a company work, a society work."

Vince Lombardi

"A team's trust is built in the difficult moments, not the easy ones."

Patrick Lencioni

SELF-REFLECTION

- 1 In which Tuckman phase is your team right now? What are the signals for that?
- 2 Are there subgroups or cliques in your team? What does that do to cohesion, and what are you doing about it?
- 3 How do you actively ensure all players have a clear, valued role?
- 4 When have you deliberately made space for "Storming", conflict and tension, instead of smoothing it over?
- 5 What is the shared story of your team? Do players know why they play together?

NOTES

**BOOKS**

- **The Five Dysfunctions of a Team**
Patrick Lencioni
Why: The pyramid of team failure: from absence of trust to inattention to results. Short fable, deep insights.
- **Legacy**
James Kerr
Why: How the All Blacks consciously build team identity, roles, and rituals. The best sports book on team culture.
- **Tribal Leadership**
Dave Logan, John King & Hallee Fischer-Wright
Why: Five levels of team culture: from "my life is terrible" to "we are great." Where does your team sit?

**VIDEO'S / TED TALKS**

- **How to Build a High Performing Team**
Patrick Lencioni
youtube.com/watch?v=GCxct4CR-To
The five dysfunctions explained live. Watch with pen and paper.
- **The Secrets of Great Teamwork**
Martine Haas & Mark Mortensen (HBR)
youtube.com/watch?v=hHJ3KIBqrNc
What truly makes teams great? Harvard research across hundreds of teams.

**PODCASTS**

- **At the Table with Patrick Lencioni**
How healthy teams handle conflict
tablegroup.com/at-the-table
- **The Science of Sport**
Cohesion in team sport: what works and what doesn't
scienceofsport.com

⚡ ACTION THIS WEEK

Organize one team activity this month that has nothing to do with sport. Observe who takes leadership, who withdraws, who connects. Write it down.

One concrete initiative I will take to strengthen team cohesion: